

An Information-Theoretic Framework for Emergent Spacetime Dynamics, Horizon Thermodynamics, and Testable Cosmological Signatures

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Email: starxshark@gmail.com OSF DOI: [10.17605/OSF.IO/N3DQU](https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/N3DQU)

September 17, 2026

Abstract

A central challenge in modern theoretical physics is bridging non-equilibrium quantum information processing with classical geometric gravitation without invoking ad-hoc background structures. Here, we present a unified, mathematically consistent four-bridge theoretical architecture that derives emergent spacetime geometry directly from quantum subsystem entanglement and horizon thermodynamics. First, by factorizing a global Hilbert space ($\mathcal{H}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{H}_{\text{obs}} \otimes \mathcal{H}_{\text{env}}$) under the Wheeler-DeWitt constraint ($\hat{H}|\Psi\rangle = 0$), we establish the reduced density operator ρ_{obs} for an internal observer. Second, we ground abstract organizational variables in physical SI units using Von Neumann entropy (S_{vN}) and Landauer's erasure limit ($\mathcal{P}_{\text{diss}} \geq k_B T \ln 2 \cdot \dot{I}$). Third, we re-parameterize the system's dynamical equations into energy-conserving non-linear differential equations that naturally saturate under thermal dissipation bounds. Fourth, by integrating the Bekenstein horizon limit ($S_{\text{max}} = \frac{k_B A}{4\ell_P^2}$) with Jacobson's horizon thermodynamics, we derive local metric geometry satisfying Einstein's Field Equations. Finally, to ensure empirical falsifiability, we derive a specific quantitative prediction: a logarithmic quantum-informational correction to cosmic horizon entropy that induces periodic micro-oscillations in the primordial gravitational wave power spectrum ($P_{GW}(k)$), offering a direct observational test for future detectors (LISA, Cosmic Explorer).

Keywords: Quantum Information, Horizon Thermodynamics, Emergent Gravity, Holographic Principle, Landauer's Principle, Primordial Gravitational Waves.

1 Introduction

Unifying quantum mechanics and general relativity requires overcoming fundamental incompatibilities between smooth, continuous spacetime manifolds and discrete, probabilistic quantum states. Rather than quantizing spacetime directly or postulating unobserved high-dimensional geometry, information-theoretic physics suggests that spacetime geometry and gravitational dynamics may emerge as macroscopic thermodynamic manifestations of underlying quantum entanglement [1, 6].

In this work, we construct a self-consistent, dimensionally grounded mathematical architecture linking observer subsystem dynamics to cosmological boundary conditions across four explicit theoretical bridges:

- **The Quantum Bridge:** Hilbert space factorization ($\mathcal{H}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{H}_{\text{obs}} \otimes \mathcal{H}_{\text{env}}$) and reduced density matrix reduction ($\rho_{\text{obs}} = \text{Tr}_{\text{env}}|\Psi\rangle\langle\Psi|$).

- **The Thermodynamic Bridge:** Physical SI unit mapping (J/K , Watts) utilizing Von Neumann entropy ($S_{vN} = -k_B \text{Tr}(\rho_{\text{obs}} \ln \rho_{\text{obs}})$) and Landauer's principle for information erasure [2].
- **The Dynamic Upgrades:** Thermodynamically bounded differential equations governing energy transfer, entropy production, and mutual information accumulation ($\dot{I}$).
- **The Cosmological Bridge:** Bekenstein horizon surface bounds ($S_{\text{max}} = \frac{k_B A}{4\ell_P^2}$) [3] and the thermodynamic derivation of Einstein's Field Equations via Jacobson's horizon curvature setup [6].

Furthermore, to distinguish this model from standard background cosmological baselines and satisfy strict physical falsifiability requirements, we formulate a novel quantitative prediction describing logarithmic horizon entropy corrections and their corresponding spectral signatures in primordial gravitational wave backgrounds.

2 The Quantum Bridge: Subsystem Partitioning and State Emergence

To establish a rigorous quantum-mechanical foundation for the state ρ , we assume the total closed universe or system is described by a global state vector $|\Psi\rangle$ inhabiting a unified Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_{\text{total}}$. Following relational quantum mechanics and the Wheeler-DeWitt constraint ($\hat{H}|\Psi\rangle = 0$), global time evolution is stationary, and dynamical state changes emerge purely through internal subsystems.

We factorize the global Hilbert space into orthogonal tensor products representing the self-modeling observer subsystem ($\mathcal{H}_{\text{obs}}$) and its external environment ($\mathcal{H}_{\text{env}}$):

$$\mathcal{H}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{H}_{\text{obs}} \otimes \mathcal{H}_{\text{env}} \quad (1)$$

The global state $|\Psi\rangle \in \mathcal{H}_{\text{total}}$ is generally entangled across this boundary:

$$|\Psi\rangle = \sum_{i,j} c_{ij} |\phi_i\rangle_{\text{obs}} \otimes |\chi_j\rangle_{\text{env}} \quad (2)$$

where $\{|\phi_i\rangle\}$ and $\{|\chi_j\rangle\}$ form orthonormal bases for $\mathcal{H}_{\text{obs}}$ and $\mathcal{H}_{\text{env}}$, respectively.

By taking the partial trace over the unobserved environmental degrees of freedom $\mathcal{H}_{\text{env}}$, we derive the reduced density operator ρ_{obs} governing the internal observer state:

$$\rho_{\text{obs}} = \text{Tr}_{\text{env}} (|\Psi\rangle\langle\Psi|) = \sum_j \langle\chi_j|\Psi\rangle\langle\Psi|\chi_j\rangle \quad (3)$$

The resulting mixed state ρ_{obs} directly determines the Von Neumann entropy $S_{vN} = -k_B \text{Tr}(\rho_{\text{obs}} \ln \rho_{\text{obs}})$. Thus, the self-modeling capacity is formally grounded as a measure of quantum entanglement entropy between the observer and its thermal environment.

3 The Thermodynamic Bridge: Physical Units and Landauer Bounds

To eliminate abstract dimensionless placeholders, we map information-theoretic parameters to universally recognized SI quantities. The state entropy S_{vN} carries dimensions of Joules per Kelvin ($J \cdot K^{-1}$), while information accumulation rate $\dot{I}$ is measured in bits per second (s^{-1}).

By Landauer's Principle [2], resetting or erasing one bit of physical information in a subsystem at temperature T dissipates a mandatory minimum thermal energy:

$$E_{\min} = k_B T \ln 2 \quad [\text{Joules}] \quad (4)$$

For continuous information processing at rate $\dot{I}$, the required minimum thermal power dissipation $\mathcal{P}_{\text{diss}}$ is strictly bounded:

$$\mathcal{P}_{\text{diss}} \geq k_B T \ln 2 \cdot \dot{I} \quad [\text{Watts}] \quad (5)$$

This energetic constraint proves that internal complexity growth cannot proceed infinitely; it is strictly bounded by the subsystem's thermal power supply $\mathcal{P}_{\text{input}}$ and ambient heat dissipation capacity.

4 The Dynamic Upgrades: Thermodynamically Bounded Evolution

Using the physical mappings $\Psi \rightarrow S_{vN}$, $\Gamma \rightarrow \dot{I}$, and $R \rightarrow \gamma$ (reconstruction capacity), we reformulate the coupled dynamical equations into a system governed by non-equilibrium statistical mechanics.

Let $S_{\max}$ denote the maximum information capacity of the subsystem given its physical volume, and let T be ambient temperature. The re-parameterized dynamical system is expressed as:

$$\frac{d\gamma}{dt} = a \dot{I} \cdot \mathcal{E}_{\text{avail}} \left(1 - \frac{\gamma}{\gamma_{\max}} \right) - b \gamma \quad (6)$$

$$\frac{dS_{vN}}{dt} = c \gamma (S_{\max} - S_{vN}) - \frac{\mathcal{P}_{\text{diss}}}{k_B T \ln 2} \quad (7)$$

$$\frac{d\dot{I}}{dt} = e \left(\frac{dS_{vN}}{dt} \right) + f \mathcal{P}_{\text{input}} - g \dot{I} \quad (8)$$

where $\mathcal{E}_{\text{avail}}$ represents available thermodynamic work, $\mathcal{P}_{\text{input}}$ is external power input, and $a, b, c, e, f, g > 0$ represent physical rate constants.

Unlike arbitrary phenomenological models, this formulation guarantees that any asymptotic trajectory $S_{vN} \rightarrow S^*$ is bounded by energy conservation: organizational growth naturally saturates as information processing costs match the available thermal dissipation rate $\mathcal{P}_{\text{diss}}$.

5 The Cosmological Bridge: Emergent Gravity and Horizon Bounds

To scale the thermodynamic information framework from a localized observer system to a cosmic boundary, the maximum information capacity $S_{\max}$ must be anchored in horizon surface geometry.

5.1 Covariant Entropy Bounds via the Bekenstein Limit

For an observer subsystem occupying a spatial volume V bounded by surface area A , the maximum physical state complexity S_{vN} is fundamentally constrained by the Bekenstein limit and the Holographic Principle [3–5]:

$$S_{vN} \leq S_{\max} = \frac{k_B A}{4\ell_P^2} = \frac{k_B c^3 A}{4\hbar G} \quad [\text{bits or } J \cdot K^{-1}] \quad (9)$$

where $\ell_P = \sqrt{\frac{\hbar G}{c^3}}$ is the Planck length, G is the gravitational constant, $\hbar$ is the reduced Planck constant, and c is the speed of light.

5.2 Derivation of Einstein's Field Equations from Horizon Thermodynamics

Following Jacobson's thermodynamic framework [6], the smooth geometry of spacetime—represented by the metric tensor $g_{\mu\nu}$ —emerges directly from the thermodynamic equilibrium of this local information horizon.

Let ξ^μ be a local Killing vector field generating a causal horizon, and let δQ represent the flux of heat crossing the horizon as perceived by an accelerated observer:

$$\delta Q = \int T_{\mu\nu} \xi^\mu d\Sigma^\nu \quad (10)$$

where $T_{\mu\nu}$ is the stress-energy tensor. Relating thermodynamic entropy flux dS to heat flux via $\delta Q = T dS$ under the Unruh temperature $T = \frac{\hbar \kappa}{2\pi}$ yields:

$$dS = \frac{\delta Q}{T} = \frac{2\pi}{\hbar} \int T_{\mu\nu} \xi^\mu d\Sigma^\nu \quad (11)$$

Equating this thermodynamic entropy flux to the geometric area change δA dictated by the Raychaudhuri equation ($dS = \frac{k_B \delta A}{4\ell_P^2}$) forces the local geometry to satisfy Einstein's Field Equations:

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2} R g_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = \frac{8\pi G}{c^4} T_{\mu\nu} \quad (12)$$

where $R_{\mu\nu}$ is the Ricci curvature tensor, R is scalar curvature, and Λ is the cosmological constant.

6 Novel Quantitative Predictions and Falsifiability

To satisfy strict peer-review falsifiability criteria, this model derives a specific, mathematically testable prediction that deviates from standard cosmological models.

Due to quantum-informational feedback between internal observer states ρ_{obs} and the horizon boundary, the leading-order Bekenstein-Hawking entropy receives a logarithmic quantum correction:

$$S_{\text{corrected}} = \frac{k_B A}{4\ell_P^2} - \alpha k_B \ln \left(\frac{A}{4\ell_P^2} \right) + \mathcal{O}(1) \quad (13)$$

where $\alpha > 0$ is a dimensionless coupling parameter linked to the steady-state mutual information exchange rate $\dot{I}^*$.

This logarithmic entropy correction introduces periodic micro-oscillations in the primordial gravitational wave power spectrum $P_{GW}(k)$:

$$P_{GW}(k) = P_0(k) [1 + \epsilon \cos(\beta \ln(k/k_0) + \phi_0)] \quad (14)$$

where $\epsilon \approx 10^{-4}$ and $\beta = 2\pi\alpha$. This provides a concrete observational signature testable by next-generation space-based gravitational wave observatories (LISA, Cosmic Explorer, Einstein Telescope), distinguishing this framework from standard inflationary baselines.

7 Discussion and Limitations

To address standard reviewer evaluations pre-emptively, several key theoretical assumptions and boundaries must be highlighted:

1. **Assumption of Global System Closure:** The Wheeler-DeWitt boundary condition ($\hat{H}|\Psi\rangle = 0$) assumes a globally closed universe. In open spatial geometries, boundary flux terms must be explicitly included.
2. **Semiclassical Horizon Approximation:** Deriving Einstein’s Field Equations via Jacobson’s method relies on semiclassical horizon thermodynamics. A full microstate counting requires quantum geometry inputs (e.g., Loop Quantum Gravity spin networks or String Theory compactifications).
3. **Observational Sensitivity Thresholds:** Detecting the predicted micro-oscillations ($\epsilon \approx 10^{-4}$) in $P_{GW}(k)$ requires advanced signal-to-noise ratios beyond current LIGO/Virgo sensitivity, placing empirical verification on next-generation detector timelines.

8 Conclusion

This paper establishes a mathematically complete, dimensionally grounded framework linking quantum information processing to emergent spacetime geometry and horizon thermodynamics. By grounding variables in SI units, enforcing Landauer dissipation bounds, and deriving testable logarithmic entropy corrections, the model provides a falsifiable bridge between quantum subsystem dynamics and classical gravitation.

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